

ChatGPT vs Claude vs Gemini

Who is winning the AI war in India in 2026?

—By **Jayesh Shinde**

Ever since the AI chatbot “war” began in 2023, when ChatGPT announced itself to the world and captured everyone’s imagination, it has always felt like OpenAI versus everyone else. ChatGPT was first, encapsulated AI as a category, and had raced to 100 million users faster than anything in history.

Everyone else from Anthropic’s Claude to Google’s Gemini was competing for second place – no exaggeration. But as unbelievable as it sounds,

interesting number: 46%. Because that was ChatGPT’s share of the AI assistant market in May 2026, across mobile apps, mobile web and desktop web, claimed Sensor Tower’s State of AI 2026 report.

What should be worrying for OpenAI is that ChatGPT’s position had slipped below 50% for the first time in March 2026. Gemini stood at 28%, Claude at 10%, and suddenly the competition looks like it’s gaining serious ground.

In India, based on Sensor Tower’s latest numbers, ChatGPT has 330 million monthly active users, followed by Google Gemini at 229 million. Claude

that Anthropic’s assistant has grown through reputation rather than ubiquity, attracting users who care about coding, better long-form reasoning and value AI safety. Sensor Tower says Claude’s US share climbed from roughly 5% in December 2025 to nearly 14% by May 2026. In India, too, it’s a similar story, where Claude numbers jumped from 28 million in Feb 2026 to over 72 million in May 2026. Its total audience was up 452% year-on-year in May.

Following OpenAI’s agreement to work with the US Department of War, ChatGPT uninstalls spiked roughly 200% above average in the US during the week of March 9–15. Claude, after declining a Pentagon partnership, briefly recorded more daily downloads than ChatGPT from March 1–5. Brand loyalty didn’t matter in the face of ethics and morality, it seemed, as people chose one app instead of another.

That should unsettle every AI company. The models may be enormously expensive to build, but switching between them costs the consumer almost nothing. A subscription can be cancelled with a click, and just as easily conversation history can increasingly be exported or recreated.

The arrival of advertising adds another complication. ChatGPT began testing ads in early 2026, and Sensor Tower says impressions grew more than sevenfold between March and May. Retention, therefore, becomes as important as intelligence.

ChatGPT’s churned-user share rose from 12.7% in January to 14.5% in April, while Claude’s declined. ChatGPT still retains users better, but Claude is closing the gap while simultaneously adding newcomers. On this front, OpenAI is learning quickly how scale creates gravity, not immunity.

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that era of unrivalled march onwards for ChatGPT and brand OpenAI may be coming to an end. Not before some more good news, however.

In its latest State of AI 2026 report, Sensor Tower proclaimed ChatGPT becoming the fastest mobile app ever to reach one billion monthly users in May 2026. That is an extraordinary achievement, just three years after launch. The likes of TikTok, YouTube and Instagram defeated by a chatbot suggested just how mainstream AI had become in people’s lives around the world.

And yet, tucked beneath that billion-user victory headline is the more

is a distant third at just over 72 million monthly users in India, and Perplexity’s has nosedived dangerously low to barely over 29 million monthly users in India.

Gemini’s rise is predictable, since it enjoys an advantage in distribution. Google can weave Gemini through Android, Search, Workspace and wider Google ecosystem, placing AI wherever users already are. ChatGPT may still be the destination people consciously visit, but the experience isn’t as seamless or intuitive as firing up Gemini inside contextual Google apps, for instance..

Claude’s rise is different, and possibly more intriguing. It can be argued